write this, Chanderpaul has now played more than 150 Test matches in his career. He has been one of the most consistent middle-order batsmen for the West Indies for close to two decades, which is remarkable. We followed up the bowling with a good batting effort and managed a small first-innings lead. I scored 92 and was wrongly given out to an Ian Bishop delivery by umpire Lloyd Barker. Replays showed that Bishop had overstepped by at least four inches and it was a key moment in the match. As things turned out, Lloyd Barker wasn't able to officiate for much of the match after that because – as I was told by the stand-in umpire who replaced him – he had had to go to hospital with a serious headache and couldn't focus properly.

In the second innings our bowlers did well to dismiss the West Indies for 140 on the third day of the match. This time Abey Kuruvilla picked up 5–68 and we needed 120 runs to win, on a pitch that was increasingly uneven, with plenty of wear and tear for the West Indian fast bowlers to exploit. We picked up two of those runs without loss in the few overs we had to see out at the end of Sunday's play. On that track we knew that scoring would not be easy the next day, but we also felt that one good partnership should be enough to take us to victory.

A humiliating collapse

Monday 31 March 1997 was a dark day in the history of Indian cricket and definitely the worst of my captaincy career. And yet it had promised so much. In fact, over dinner at a restaurant in St Lawrence Gap in Barbados the night before, I remember having a joke with the waiter, who was predicting a West Indian win. He was confident that Ambrose would bounce India out the next morning. Now, in the first innings of this match, Franklyn Rose had bowled me a bouncer and I had pulled him into the stands for six. So I reminded the waiter of the shot and jokingly said to him that if Ambrose tried to bowl me a bouncer, I would hit him all the way to Antigua. I was so confident of our chances that I pointed to the fridge and said he should immediately chill a bottle of champagne and I would come and open it the next day and pour him a glass to celebrate winning the match.

Instead, we collapsed for a miserable 81 all out, handing the West Indies a 38-run victory. Frankly, there can be no excuses for such a poor batting effort, even though it was a difficult track. I certainly don't want